

The Paradigm Discourses

“Royally Confused”

Quote.

“Has he been sitting there all evening?”

Curiosity turned to face Dogma, the question still evident on his face.

She paused, then, “I think so, he hasn’t moved and hasn’t moved any pieces either.”

“What is he doing? It’s a stupid chess opening, both royal pawns double advanced. He can’t seriously be considering this as a strategically sound opening. He’s weird, unconventional, but not stupid. Both pawns are blocked for advance, and all four have one capture possibility. No where to go and everything at risk.”

Reason, cigar in hand, approached them, his smirk unhidden by the local cloud of smoke, “He’s thinking.”

Dogma whipped around, “About what, strategy, tactics, an upcoming tournament? Oh no...he’s thinking about physics.”

Reason smiled, “Dollars to donuts.” He took a puff. “Notice the symmetry of the position – oh, hay, he’s moving.” That pulled them over for a closer look.

Paradigm, oblivious to his environment, having finally stirred, picked up a pen, and wrote down the next two moves of the game...

PxP PxP

then sat back down into exactly the same position as before.

Reason snuffed out his cigar, looked at Dogma who was looking at him too. In unscripted unison, they whispered what all three were thinking, “which pawn?”

Logic joined them, the tableau a curiosity he could not resist. “Say, that’s not standard notation. He has to specify which pawn is doing the capturing.”

“Or which one is being captured,” Reason responded.

Dogma glared at him.

“Or,” Curiosity chimed in, “both. KP takes QP, or QP takes KP, you know, just to over resolve the ambiguity.”

“Yes,” Reason exhaled, “but he is not enforcing classical chess notation.”

“Of course not, why would Paradigm do things the standard way? It shows a lack of respect for the game.”

Reason ignored the outburst, and continued thinking out loud, “If I had to hazard a guess, I’d say it is the very fact that standard notation has to add an element to capture notation when there is more than one possibility that has him so fixated on this position. He wants to know what the *unresolved* ambiguity is all about.”

Paradigm shuddered, stood, and then with a slight flinch, noticed the group. “*Sigh*, how long have you all been standing there?”

“Long enough to find ourselves trying to get to wherever you are headed as fast as you do.”

Dogma, “Maybe not all of us.” Reason and Logic grinned.

Curiosity, “There is not just one next position is there, I see two: both pawns in the king file or both pawns in the queen file. In both cases, they have passed each other.”

Dogma, “And that ambiguity is the problem. The state of the game is underspecified.”

Logic, “No, not an under specification, a *superposition*. There are now two possible games of chess in play. Very clever, Paradigm, very clever. You have introduced superposition into classical chess simply by relaxing a notational standard.”

Reason, “And that is the conceptual breakthrough – the demand of classical thinking to have only one possibility. It is that commonsense constraint that led to, no *forced*, the addition of new notation, notation that demands disambiguating which pawn is doing the capturing.

“You must really hate classical thinking.”

Paradigm shrugged, “I like knowing why, I am drawn to alternatives, and I don’t like limits.”

“Ok, out with it.” Curiosity had her hands on her hip, “What does this mean for physics?”

Dogma sat down, resigned to the inevitable. Looking around, he could see that the rest of team had wandered over as well. *Sigh*.

Paradigm grinned, “Oh, this is interesting, this is going to be fun. Attend...”